



Should I admit my wrongdoings? Examining stealing thunder in the context of performance evaluations

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ABSTRACT

Stealing thunder is a self-disclosure strategy in which people reveal negative information about themselves before another person does so to reduce its negative impact on an audience. The present study examines stealing thunder as a trust tactic that employees might find useful for overcoming prior workplace mistakes during performance evaluation processes. Using hospitality managers in a between-subjects experimental design, Study 1 examined the impact of stealing thunder on manager evaluations of employees' performance. The findings indicated that employees' use of stealing thunder led to significantly better performance evaluations than when they did not apply the strategy. Study 2 confirmed the findings of Study 1 after controlling for mistake severity. Study 3 data examined the impact of accepting responsibility on performance evaluations. The results indicated that when employees adopted the stealing thunder strategy, their acceptance of responsibility resulted in significantly better performance evaluations than blaming others for the mistakes.

1. Introduction

Scholars and practitioners have been interested in the evaluation of employees' performance at work, performance appraisal, for many years (DeNisi and Murphy, 2017; Bayo-Moriones et al., 2020). *Performance appraisal* refers to a formal process by which an assessor (typically an employee's supervisor) evaluates the employees' performance based on a set of criteria and assigns a score to that assessment (DeNisi and Murphy, 2017). Organizations often use these ratings/scores to make a variety of crucial decisions concerning the employees, such as salary increases, discretionary bonuses, dismissals, and promotions (Eyoum et al., 2020). As a result, employees strive to impress their employers/assessors to get high appraisals (Barrick et al., 2009).

Impression management has been defined as behaviors that employees use to protect their self-images, and/or influence the way they are perceived by others (e.g., managers/assessors) (Wayne and Liden, 1995). Extensive research has been done in impression management because of its influence on important employee outcomes, such as performance evaluations and career advancement (e.g., Bolino et al., 2008). Research has generally focused on how employees use assertive impression management tactics (ingratiation and self-promotion) or

defensive tactics (apologies and justification) to enhance their workplace image and supervisor ratings of likability and performance (Bolino et al., 2014). Ingratiation refers to strategies that employees use to appear likable such as flattery and favor-doing (Bolino et al., 2014; Ferris et al., 1994; Jones and Pittman, 1982). Self-promotion involves tactics used to appear competent, such as taking credit for positive events and highlighting one's performance (Barrick et al., 2009; Bolino et al., 2014; Ellis et al., 2002). Apologies and justifications control damage following a negative event to reduce the blame associated with failure (Crant and Bateman, 1993; Frantz and Bennis, 2005; Wood and Mitchell, 1981). These are typically traditional reactive strategies when an individual has been confronted with allegations of wrongdoing and/or found guilty of negative performance by others (e.g., managers, coworkers) (Krylova et al., 2018). However, another impression management tactic that can influence performance evaluations needs to be investigated: stealing thunder.

Stealing thunder is defined as revealing negative information about oneself before it is revealed or elicited by someone else (Williams et al., 1993). This proactive self-disclosure of negative information tends to minimize its effects because of increased credibility and overall favorable ratings of the source (Krylova et al., 2018). Stealing thunder and its

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positive impacts have been found in various contexts, such as jury studies, crisis management communications, service failure and recovery, and job interviews (Williams et al., 1993; Claeys et al., 2013; Krylova et al., 2018; Guchait et al., 2019). The current study focused on stealing thunder as a strategy that can influence performance evaluations.

1.1. Purpose

The overall purpose of the current study was to examine whether preemptive self-disclosure of negative performance information by employees positively influences their performance evaluations (performance ratings during performance appraisals). The first objective was to examine whether stealing thunder strategy (employee self-disclosure of their workplace mistakes) resulted in significantly better performance evaluations than when stealing thunder strategy was not used (Study 1). Performance evaluations was assessed by measuring task, contextual, and overall performance. Since mistake severity can influence the impact of stealing thunder on performance evaluations, Study 1 was replicated while controlling for mistake severity (Study 2). The second objective was to examine that when stealing strategy was being used, whether accepting responsibility led to higher performance evaluations compared to blaming others (Study 3). The third objective was to examine the mediating effect of trust (Study 1, 2, and 3). Study 1 highlighted how stealing thunder influences performance evaluations via trust. The study investigated whether employees applying the stealing thunder strategy increased the raters' perceptions of trust, consequently influencing performance evaluations positively. The relationships tested in Study 1 were reexamined in Study 2 after controlling for mistake severity. Study 3 highlighted that along with stealing thunder when employees accepted responsibility (vs blaming others) for the mistake, lead to increased perceptions of trust, consequently influencing performance evaluations positively.

1.2. Research gaps, contributions, and originality

Based on its objectives, the current study addresses several research gaps and makes several critical contributions. First, while researchers have extensively examined performance appraisal in disciplines such as management, psychology, and human resources, little research exists in a hospitality context. Implementing performance appraisals is crucial for hospitality organizations to attract and retain employees (Eyoum et al., 2020). Effective performance appraisal programs functions to timely and continuously recognize employees' contribution to customer experiences, as such evaluating and enhancing organizational service quality (Cheung and Law, 1998). A qualitative study with frontline hospitality employees in Hong Kong found that employees valued performance appraisals and perceived it as an important communication approach in leader-member interactions, a representation of organizational justice, and a motivational stimulus for personal development (Law and Tam, 2007). Likewise, Narban et al. (2016) revealed that 95.6 % of participants, who worked in Indian hotels, consented on the necessity of examining performance appraisals to assist them improve service performance. A recent study by Eyoum et al. (2020) acknowledged that performance appraisal is a neglected area of research in the hospitality industry, and they examined the relationship between the purpose of performance appraisals and psychological contract. The current study addresses this research gap by focusing on the context of performance appraisals in hospitality work settings. This study can help open a new line of research for hospitality and tourism scholars in a critical area that has been mostly ignored – performance appraisal process in the hospitality industry. Hospitality scholars can develop a nomological network including factors that influence employee performance ratings during performance appraisals (antecedents), outcomes of the performance appraisals (e.g., promotions, dismissals), mediators that explain the underlying mechanisms, and moderators that influence such

relationships (e.g., national culture, employee tenure). This line of research has great implications for industry practitioners, given the importance of performance appraisals/evaluations for employee and organizational success (DeNisi and Murphy, 2017).

Second, in the domain of impression management research, although the impact of impression management on job interview and job performance ratings has been researched in the areas of human resources, management, and psychology, this salient psychological literature has not drawn sufficient attention in the hospitality domain. As exceptions, two tourism research teams recently examined the influence of impression management techniques used by tour guides on the quality of tourist-guide interactions (Kalyoncu and Yuksek, 2017; Zhu and Xu, 2021). Meaningful as these explorations are, these two studies conceptualized impression management as tactics to provide better service outcomes in the hospitality service context. By contrast, the current research considers impression management within the human resources management domain, thus switching the context from employee-customer to subordinates-supervisor interactions. By doing so, we provide a novel angle, namely employees' perspective, to understand impression management in the hospitality work setting. Impression management is salient in the hospitality organizations for two reasons. First, hospitality organizations normally emphasize the significance of impression management during employee induction training, such as grooming and code of behaviors, to demonstrate employees' respectfulness, professionalism, and warmth to supervisors, coworkers, and customers (Min et al., 2023). For instance, hotels encourage frontline employees to keep smiling and eye-contact, as both emotional labor and impression management tactics, during the service production and delivery (Cheng et al., 2022). Second, in light of the increased experienced performance pressure and scarce opportunity for promotion in hospitality organizations, employees tend to engage in impression management for the sake of increasing their perceived value within the organization (Agina et al., 2017). Scholars have found that hospitality employees who conduct impression management approaches (i.e., self-promotion and exemplification) is likely to ameliorate their leader-member exchange and organizational citizenship behavior, such as help seeking (Omoankhanlen and Issa, 2021; Agina et al., 2017). The current study can encourage other hospitality scholars to focus on the topic of employees' impression management in hospitality work settings. This topic has great implications for hospitality managers, given the influence of impression management techniques on job performance ratings (Peck and Levashina, 2017).

Most importantly, no research in any discipline has investigated stealing thunder as an impression management technique to influence performance evaluations. Stealing thunder as a persuasion/communication strategy has mostly been studied in jury and crisis communication research. Krylova et al. (2018) examined the stealing thunder strategy in the context of selection interviews. Specific to hospitality research, the only study is by Guchait et al. (2019) in which stealing thunder was introduced as a service recovery strategy to influence customers' trust and loyalty. The current research is the first to investigate whether the stealing thunder strategy can influence employees' performance evaluations. A major contribution of this study is examining the influence of stealing thunder from the employees' perspective. This area of research has strong implications for managers and employees. Using stealing thunder during performance appraisals can be effective for employees but also runs the risk of being ineffective. It is ineffective when presenting the negative performance information creates a negative impression about the employee that can bias the rater's/supervisor's perception of other available information about the employee, leading to unfavorable outcomes. It can be effective, however, because the raters/supervisors might regard the employees as credible, honest, and trustworthy, leading to favorable outcomes. As such, employees face an ethical dilemma about revealing negative information since it can hurt their chances of getting promotions and/or increased pay. Managers also face a dilemma: whether they should reward employees for their

honesty in revealing their mistake(s), or hold them accountable and discipline them. The study makes another contribution by considering the attribution tendency of hospitality employees, which may influence the effectiveness of stealing thunder. Although the study justifies that stealing thunder can result in positive performance evaluations, we also argue that the effectiveness of stealing thunder may vary as a function of different situations. Using attribution theory, the study proposes that stealing thunder can be effective when employees also take responsibility for the mistake; on the contrary, employees' blaming others for the mistake can backfire (i.e., effectiveness of stealing thunder may be lowered). The current research can help shed more light on these issues and can help employees and managers handle workplace mistakes better.

2. Literature review and hypothesis development

2.1. Stealing thunder

Stealing thunder is a self-disclosure strategy in which individuals reveal negative information about themselves before someone else does to reduce its negative impact on an evaluative audience (e.g., managers evaluating employee performances) (Williams et al., 1993; Dolnik et al., 2003). Research on stealing thunder began in the area of law studies. Researchers demonstrated that when a defendant admitted something compromising during a trial before the prosecutor revealed it, a mock jury considered the defendant less guilty than when the prosecution revealed the negative information (Williams et al., 1993; Dolnik et al., 2003). Researchers have also studied the stealing thunder strategy in the area of crisis communication research. Organizations can select between two crisis timing strategies. Ex-antecrisis timing strategy (stealing thunder) – referred to as a self-disclosure strategy in which an organization is the first to offer information on a crisis to its stakeholders, before another party (e.g., media, government) does (Arpan and Pompper, 2003). Ex-postcrisis timing strategy involves organizations waiting to respond to inquiries from the media or other third parties (Claeys and Cauberghe, 2012). Researchers found that ex-antecrisis timing strategy (compared to ex-postcrisis) led to more positive evaluations of organizations in crisis and a less negative postcrisis reputation, caused stakeholders to consider the crisis as less severe, and minimized further crisis damage (Arpan and Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Claeys et al., 2013). Stealing thunder has recently been used in organizational psychology in the context of selection interviews. Researchers investigated whether proactively admitting a prior wrongdoing in a previous company (stealing thunder) might be beneficial for applicants during job interviews. Krylova et al. (2018) argued that the stealing thunder tactic may be better than more traditional defensive strategies that applicants use after being faced with accusations of wrongdoing. Guchait et al. (2019) explored stealing thunder in a hospitality service recovery study. They investigated whether customers' service recovery evaluations would vary if the customers identified a service failure first versus if the service provider identified it first and took the initiative to report the failure to the customer (stealing thunder). They found that when stealing thunder was used as a preemptive service recovery strategy, customer loyalty increased.

The current study examines whether employees' preemptive self-disclosure of negative performance information positively influences their performance evaluations (performance ratings during performance appraisals). The effect of stealing thunder can be explained using the inoculation theory (McGuire, 1961). It is based on the biological analogy of triggering a body's immune system against a virus by controlling the body's exposure to a weakened form of the virus, allowing the body to produce antibodies, consequently building resistance to more critical attacks (Krylova et al., 2018). The inoculation theory suggests that individuals can be immunized against attacks on their attitudes in a similar manner (McGuire and Papageorgis, 1962). Employees' proactive disclosure of negative performance information likely acts as

inoculation by lessening the effects of the negative information.

The current study also argues that trust will mediate the relationship between stealing thunder and performance evaluations. This study justifies that stealing thunder (compared to no stealing thunder) leads to more positive performance evaluations because of increased trust. Research on impression formation suggests that if individuals self-disclose information that appears to be against their own best interests, they are perceived as more credible (Eagly et al., 1978). When individuals revealed negative information about themselves, they were also perceived as more likable because they were seen as more honest and up-front (Archer and Burleson, 1980; Williams et al., 1993). Guchait et al. (2019) noted that when stealing thunder was used as a service recovery strategy, it increased customer's trust toward the service provider, leading to increased customer loyalty. Krylova et al. (2018) suggested stealing thunder as a trust repair method that might be helpful for overcoming prior indiscretions. Therefore, when employees take the initiative to disclose their own negative performance information, their assessors (supervisors) are more likely to consider them trustworthy, leading to more positive performance evaluations.

Therefore, the current study argues that the stealing thunder strategy (employee self-disclosure of their workplace mistakes) will result in significantly better performance evaluations because of increased trust than when the stealing thunder strategy is not used. The following hypotheses are proposed:

H1. : Stealing thunder compared to no-stealing thunder will have a stronger positive impact on: (a) task performance evaluation; (b) citizenship performance evaluation; and (c) overall performance evaluation.

H2. : Trust will mediate the relationship between Stealing thunder (vs. no stealing thunder) and: (a) task performance evaluation; (b) citizenship performance evaluation; and (c) overall performance evaluation.

2.2. Accepting responsibility and stealing thunder

Additionally, employees' attribution tendency in the face of mistakes may influence appraisers' perception of employees. According to the attribution theory, individuals are motivated to analyze the causes of life events and make causal attributions accordingly (Martinko et al., 2011). Among the extensive research on attribution theory in organizational psychology, most studies focused on two forms of attribution theory, namely, the process of making attribution and the consequences of attribution (Martinko et al., 2006). In the first subfield of attribution theory, scholars take the lens of attribution theory on uncovering how individuals make attributions for an outcome, contingent on individual attribute and acquired social information (Kelley, 1973). The second subfield of attribution theory emphasizes that how individuals' attribution (i.e., internal vs. external; ability vs. effort) leads to their subsequent emotions and behaviors (Weiner, 1986). Based on the purpose of this study, we adhere to the second major thrust of attribution theory, exploring the extent to which employees' causal dimensions (internal vs. external attribution) as stealing thunder approaches influence the consequence of performance appraisals. One type of attribution common in the hospitality setting is responsibility, given the characteristics of service production. Facing failure situations, individuals can choose to attribute the mistakes either to themselves, which is internal attribution, or to other people (e.g., colleagues, customers) as external attribution. Research on service failure and recovery has extensively focused on apology as an effective service recovery strategy (Guchait et al., 2012). Following a service failure, customers tend to evaluate the service delivery/recovery process more positively when service employees and service organizations assume responsibility for the service failure (Boshoff and Leong, 1998).

Researchers have argued that accepting responsibility, as one internal attribution approach, can be a powerful impression management tactic. When individuals accept responsibility for past mistakes in a

proactive manner, they are considered more trustworthy compared to individuals who blame others for those mistakes (Krylova et al., 2018). If an employee proactively self-discloses a past mistake and then blames others for it, appraisers are more likely to consider the act as manipulative impression management instead of sincere regret. In an interview setting, Krylova et al. (2018) found that when interviewees proactively self-disclosed a wrongdoing in their previous workplace and accepted responsibility for their actions, interviewers were more likely to consider them trustworthy and high in integrity.

Building on previous research, the current study proposes that appraisees who proactively self-disclose their workplace mistakes (stealing thunder) and accept responsibility for their mistakes are likely to be better evaluated by appraisers (compared to those who blame others for their mistakes) because of increased trust. Taken together, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H3. : When Stealing thunder is present, accepting responsibility compared to blaming others will have a stronger positive impact on performance evaluations: (a) task performance evaluation; (b) citizenship performance evaluation; and (c) overall performance evaluation.

H4. : Trust will mediate the relationship between accepting responsibility (vs. blaming others) and: (a) task performance evaluation; (b) citizenship performance evaluation; and (c) overall performance evaluation.

3. Study 1

3.1. Methodology

3.1.1. Experimental design

A two-group (stealing thunder vs. no stealing thunder) between-subjects experimental design study was conducted to test hypotheses 1 and 2. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the two scenario conditions (no stealing thunder; $n = 42$, stealing thunder; $n = 39$). Respondents were asked to imagine that they were a manager in a restaurant and were responsible for conducting employees' annual performance evaluations. They were asked to imagine they had finished a performance appraisal meeting with a subordinate (line cook). The scenario provided a description of the performance evaluation meeting. In the stealing thunder scenario, the employee preemptively self-discloses a workplace mistake during the appraisal meeting. During the self-disclosure, the employee admits that last week he came to work sick. In the no stealing thunder scenario, the employee does not preemptively self-disclose the workplace mistake during the appraisal meeting. The manager gets the information about the mistake from the employee's coworker and shift manager (see Appendix A for Study's 1 scenario).

3.1.2. Sample and procedure

A survey was distributed to 91 frontline managers (62 % men and 38 % women) from different hotel properties located in the southern United States. The managers were participating in a training program offered by a hotel association. The authors served as instructors in one of the courses the managers completed. The researchers approached the managers in person after the course and invited them to complete an optional anonymous paper survey, which yielded a high response rate. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the manipulated conditions. The final sample included 81 participants. The participants' average age was 33.20 years ($SD = 9.92$), with an average tenure of 6.66 years ($SD = 74.11$) in the hospitality industry. Participants identified as 40.2 % Latino, 39 % Caucasian or White, 14.3 % Black, and 6.5 % Asian. The managers were working in different hotel departments, including sales, front desk, food and beverage, housekeeping, and human resource department.

3.1.3. Scenario development and pilot test

Following previous research (e.g., Guchait et al., 2012), the scenarios were developed in three stages. The researchers discussed relevant and realistic situations about workplace mistakes and developed scenario drafts. The drafted scenarios were revised based on consultations and discussions with several restaurant managers (outside the study sample pool) to enhance their face validity, reality, and reliability. Researcher experts with substantial knowledge about experimental research carefully reviewed and finalized the contents of the scenarios.

A pilot test was conducted with 60 hospitality students from a university in southern United States. Overall, the results confirmed the manipulations were effective (89 % of the respondents correctly answered the manipulation check/attention check questions). Respondents found the scenarios to be realistic ($M = 4.16$, $SD = 0.81$) and easy to imagine themselves in the situation ($M = 4.37$, $SD = 0.75$). Focus group interviews were also conducted with five restaurant managers and five expert researchers to verify the realism of the scenarios and to ensure that the scale items were context specific and appropriate.

3.1.4. Measures

Realism in the scenario descriptions was measured with two items (Dabholkar and Spaid, 2012) using a scale of 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). The original realism items were developed by Eroglu (1987). One factual manipulation check item was adapted from Guchait et al. (2019) to verify whether respondents understood the information presented in the scenarios. Factual manipulation checks should be used when there is only one correct answer, allowing to screen participants attentiveness to the experiment stimulus (Kane and Barabas, 2019). The item was: "The employee took the initiative to inform about their mistake." The item was developed as a dichotomous item (Yes/No). Previous research has used single-item and dichotomous items to check scenarios' manipulations (Dabholkar and Spaid, 2012; Guchait et al., 2019; Shin et al., 2022).

Citizenship performance was measured with a 16-item scale from Motowidlo and Van Scotter (1994) (Cronbach's $\alpha = .92$). A sample item is "Cooperate with others in the team." The original scale items were identified by Borman and Motowidlo (1993). Twelve items from Coole (2003) were used to measure task performance (Cronbach's $\alpha = .89$). A sample item is "Make informed decisions." Six items were adapted from Kiffin-Petersen and Cordery (2003) to measure trust (Cronbach's $\alpha = .85$). A sample item is "I will have confidence in the skills of this employee." The original scale items were developed by Cook and Wall (1980). Adapting scale items to measure the constructs is a common practice (Choi and Choi, 2014). Citizenship performance and task performance were measured on a scale of 1 (not at all likely) to 5 (extremely likely). Trust was measured on a scale of 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

Overall performance was rated with one item following Judge and Ferris (1993). The item was "How would you rate/evaluate the overall work performance of the employee?" It was rated on a scale of 1 (very poor) to 5 (very good).

3.2. Results

To verify the manipulations' effectiveness, two steps were conducted. Respondents had to answer if the employee took the initiative to disclose their mistake. Those who failed attention checks (five participants) and did not answer the binary manipulation check (five participants) question according to their scenarios were excluded. Excluding participants that did not answer a factual manipulation check correctly is a common practice in order to have a better-quality sample and statistical power (Miwa et al., 2022; Kane and Barabas, 2019; Shin et al., 2022). And respondents found the scenario to be realistic ($M = 4.16$, $SD = 0.92$) and easy to imagine themselves in the situation ($M = 4.30$, $SD = 0.92$). ANOVA was used to test Hypothesis 1 (Table 1).

As expected, managers evaluated the employee (a) task performance

Table 1
Study 1 ANOVA results.

	Means	Sum of squares	F	Significance
H1a: ST → TP		2.21	4.66	0.03
ST	3.29			
No-ST	2.95			
H1b: ST → CP		3.33	7.14	0.009
ST	3.68			
No-ST	3.24			
H1c: ST → OP		4.16	7.73	.007
ST	3.62			
No-ST	3.15			

Note: ST = Stealing thunder, No-ST = No stealing thunder, TP = Task performance, CP = citizenship performance, OP = overall performance.

($F = 4.66$, $p < .05$, $M = 3.29$), (b) citizenship performance ($F = 7.14$, $p = .009$, $M = 3.68$), and (c) overall performance ($F = 7.73$, $p = .007$, $M = 3.62$) more positively when stealing thunder was present. Thus, Hypothesis 1 was fully supported. The effect sizes for task performance ($d = -.58$, 95 % CI $[-1.04, -.12]$), citizenship performance ($d = -.62$, 95 % CI $[-1.08, -.15]$), and overall performance ($d = -.64$, 95 % CI $[-1.10, -.17]$) were found to exceed Cohen's (1988) threshold for a medium effect ($d = .5$).

Process version 4 was used to test Hypothesis 2. A bootstrap function extracting 5000 samples was used for the analysis (95 % CI). The partially standardized mediation effects results were used due the nature of our independent variable (binary: one-unit change is relevant for this analysis). As shown in Table 2, trust mediated the relationship between stealing thunder and task performance ($b = .37$, $[.08, .64]$), citizenship performance ($b = .38$, $[.14, .60]$), and overall performance evaluation ($b = .18$, $[.02, .39]$) in support of Hypotheses 2. R^2 values indicate that 48 % of variance in task performance, 40 % of citizenship performance, and 19 % of overall performance can be explained through the relationships between variables from the model.

4. Study 2

4.1. Methodology

4.1.1. Experimental design

Study 2 used the same scenarios as Study 1. As the mistake severity may influence how supervisors evaluate employees (Krylova et al., 2018), this study controlled for severity of the mistake, aiming to reduce confounding effects. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the two scenario conditions (no stealing thunder; $n = 39$, stealing thunder; $n = 38$).

4.1.2. Sample and procedure

A survey was distributed to 77 respondents through Prolific. Respondents had to be employed in the hospitality and tourism industry in the United States (50 % men, 48.638 % women, and 1.4 % non-binary/third gender), to be 18 years or older, be fluent in English, and hold a leadership/position of power/supervisory duties position. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the manipulated conditions. The final sample consisted of 72 participants. The participants' average age was 42.93 years ($SD = 11.21$), with an average tenure of 5.17 years ($SD = 0.81$) in the hospitality industry. Participants identified as 79.2 %

Table 2
Study 1 Mediation analyses.

Hypotheses	Effects	BootSE	BootLLCI 95 %	BootULCI 95 %
H2a: ST → T → TP	.37	.14	.08	.64
H2b: ST → T → CP	.38	.12	.14	.60
H2c: ST → T → OP	.18	.10	.02	.39

Note: ST = Stealing thunder, T = trust, TP = Task performance, CP = citizenship performance, OP = overall performance.

Caucasian or white, 5.6 % s Black or African-America, 5.6 % as Hispanic or Latino, 5.6 % as Asian, and 4 % as others.

4.1.3. Measures

The same manipulation check item used in Study 1 was used in Study 2 to check whether respondents had understood the scenarios. Attention checks, realism check questions and scale items were the same as used in Study 1. Mistake severity was measured with one item developed by Brees and Martinko (2015). The item was "Based on the scenario, how severe do you think David's mistake is?". This item was measured on a scale of 1 (not severe at all) to 5 (extremely severe). The scale reliabilities were respectively: citizenship performance (Cronbach's $\alpha = .96$), task performance (Cronbach's $\alpha = .93$), and trust (Cronbach's $\alpha = .91$).

4.2. Results

Overall, the results confirmed the manipulation to be effective (93.51 % of the respondents correctly answered the manipulation check). Five participants who did not answer the binary manipulation check question according to their scenarios were excluded. All participants answered the attention check questions correctly. Respondents found the scenarios to be realistic ($M = 4.67$, $SD = 0.60$) and easy to imagine themselves in the situation ($M = 4.58$, $SD = 0.85$). Results are shown in Table 3.

Mistake severity was controlled in Study 2. Replicating the results of Study 1, managers evaluated the employee (a) task performance ($F = 11.53$, $p < .001$, $M = 3.66$), (b) citizenship performance ($F = 15.10$, $p < .001$, $M = 3.82$), and (c) overall performance ($F = 6.43$, $p = .01$, $M = 3.78$) more positively when stealing thunder was present, compared when stealing thunder was not present ($M = 3.13$; $M = 3.24$; $M = 3.32$) in support for Hypothesis 1. Mistake severity, as a covariate, did not change the significant relationships of interest.

Process version 4 was used to test Hypothesis 2. A bootstrap function extracting 5000 samples was used for the analysis (95 % CI). As shown in Table 4, after controlling for mistake severity, trust still mediated the relationship between stealing thunder and task performance ($b = .66$, $[.31, .96]$), citizenship performance ($b = .58$, $[.26, .88]$), and overall performance evaluation ($b = .59$, $[.26, .87]$) in support of Hypotheses 2. R^2 values indicate that 73 % of variance in task performance, 63 % of citizenship performance, and 61 % of overall performance can be explained through the relationships between variables from the model.

Table 3
Study 2 ANCOVA results.

Source	Sum of squares	F	Significance	Partial Eta Squared	R-squared
H1a: ST → TP					.16
Severity (covariate)	.158	.37	.543	.00	
ST	4.85	11.53	.001	.14	
H1b: ST → CP					.19
Severity (covariate)	.003	.007	.93	.00	
ST	5.80	15.19	<.001	.18	
H1c: ST → OP					.16
Severity (covariate)	2.29	4.50	.04	0.6	
ST	3.27	6.43	.01	0.9	

Note: ST = Stealing thunder, TP = Task performance, CP = citizenship performance, OP = overall performance.

Table 4
Study 2 Mediation analyses.

Hypotheses	Effects	BootSE	BootLLCI 95 %	BootULCI 95 %
H2a: ST → T → TP	.66	.17	.31	.96
H2b: ST → T → CP	.58	.15	.26	.88
H2c: ST → T → OP	.59	.16	.26	.87

5. Study 3

5.1. Methodology

5.1.1. Experimental design

To test Hypotheses 3 and 4, we conducted a two-group (accept responsibility vs. blame others) between-subjects experimental design study. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the two scenario conditions (accept responsibility = 34, blame others = 43). Study 3 was built on Study 1. The stealing thunder scenario used in Study 1 was used in both scenarios in Study 3. In addition to the subordinate preemptively self-disclosing the workplace mistake (stealing thunder), the subordinate takes full responsibility for the wrongdoing (condition 1) versus the subordinate blame others for the wrongdoing (condition 2). All other content was the same as the scenario used in Study 1. In the accept responsibility scenario, the employee admits the same mistake (stealing thunder) and acknowledges that coming to work sick was a violation, accepting responsibility. In the blame others scenario, the employee acknowledges that he was guilty of coming to work sick, but he did not accept the responsibility for it; instead, he blamed other individuals. The accept responsibility and blames others conditions were adapted from Krylova et al. (2018) (see Appendix B for Study's 3 scenario).

5.1.2. Sample and procedure

A survey was distributed to 107 frontline managers from distinct hotel properties located in the southern United States. The managers were attending a training program provided by a regional hotel association. These managers did not participate in Study 1. The data collection procedure was the same as Study 1. The managers were randomly assigned to one of the manipulated conditions. Usable data were collected from 77 managers (61.8 % men and 38.2 % women). The participants' average age was 32.30 years ($SD = 9.63$), with an average tenure of 8.75 years ($SD = 110.17$) in the hospitality industry. Participants identified as 42.7 % Caucasian or White, 32 % Latino(a), 13.3 % Black, and 12 % Asian. The frontline managers worked in different hotel departments, including sales department, the front desk, food and beverage, housekeeping, and human resource department.

5.1.3. Scenario development and pilot test

The scenario development procedure was the same as used in Study 1. A pilot test was conducted with 50 hospitality employees recruited through Prolific. Overall, the results confirmed the manipulations were effective (84 % of the respondents correctly answered the manipulation check/attention check questions). Respondents found the scenarios to be realistic ($M = 4.52$, $SD = 0.68$) and easy to imagine themselves in the situation ($M = 4.38$, $SD = 0.77$). In addition, focus group interviews were conducted with four hospitality managers and four research experts to ensure the realism of the scenarios and confirm that the scale items were pertinent and context specific.

5.1.4. Measures

One manipulation check item was used to check whether respondents had understood the scenarios: "The employee accepted responsibility for the mistake." The item was developed as a dichotomous item (Yes/No). The realism check questions and scale items were the same as used in Study 1. The scale reliabilities were respectively: citizenship performance (Cronbach's $\alpha = .92$), task performance (Cronbach's $\alpha = .91$), and trust (Cronbach's $\alpha = .86$).

5.2. Results

To verify the manipulations' effectiveness, two steps were conducted. Respondents had to answer if the employee accepted responsibility. Those who failed attention checks (21 participants) and did not answer the binary manipulation check (eight participants) question according to their scenarios were excluded. One response was excluded due to missing data. Respondents reported the study to be realistic ($M = 3.88$, $SD = 1.31$) and easy to imagine themselves in the situation ($M = 4.00$, $SD = 1.306$). Results are shown in Table 5.

As expected, managers evaluated the employee (a) task performance ($F = 12.55$, $p = .001$, $M = 3.51$), (b) citizenship performance ($F = 29.00$, $p < .001$, $M = 3.75$), and (c) overall performance ($F = 16.33$, $p < .001$, $M = 3.78$) more positively when accepting responsibility was present. Thus, Hypothesis 3 was fully supported. The effect sizes for task performance ($d = -.82$, 95 % CI $[-1.29, -.34]$), citizenship performance ($d = -1.30$, 95 % CI $[-1.82, -.77]$), and overall performance ($d = -.97$, 95 % CI $[-1.46, -.47]$) were found to exceed Cohen's (1988) threshold for a large effect ($d = .8$).

Following the same procedures from Study 1, Process version 4 was used to test Hypothesis 4 (bootstrap function extracting 5000 samples, 95 % CI). As shown in Table 6, trust mediated the relationship between accepting responsibility and task performance ($b = .71$, $[.45, 1.00]$), citizenship performance ($b = .78$, $[.51, 1.05]$), and overall performance evaluation ($b = .66$, $[.40, .94]$) in support of Hypotheses 4. R^2 values indicate that 57 % of variance in task performance, 73 % of citizenship performance, and 45 % of overall performance can be explained through the relationships between variables from the model.

6. Discussion

The current research introduces the principles of stealing thunder in the context of performance appraisal and examines its effectiveness following personal transgressions. The first objective is to examine whether the adoption of stealing thunder—employees' initiative to confess their faults—would result in appraisers' better rating compared to not stealing thunder. The results indicated that when employees used stealing thunder, managers developed more trust in them, thereby resulting in better rating outcomes. The second objective is to delineate different stealing thunder approaches based on the attribution of transgressions and investigate its impacts on performance appraisal results. Compared to blaming others, accepting responsibility was found to lead to higher levels of managers' trust and the subsequent rating outcomes. These findings not only extend the understanding of stealing thunder but also contribute to the literature on performance appraisal, impression management, and relevant theories.

6.1. Theoretical implications

The current research draws upon the principles of stealing thunder and applies them in the performance appraisal context in the hospitality

Table 5
Study 3 ANOVA results.

	Means	Sum of squares	F	Significance
H3a: AR → TP		4.84	12.55	.001
AR	3.51			
BO	3.00			
H3b: AR → CP		9.28	29.00	<.001
AR	3.75			
BO	3.01			
H3c: AR → OP		7.94	16.33	<.001
AR	3.78			
BO	3.11			

Note: AR = Accepting responsibility, BO = Blame others, TP = Task performance, CP = citizenship performance, OP = overall performance.

Table 6
Study 3 Mediation analyses.

Hypotheses	Effects	BootSE	BootLLCI 95 %	BootULCI 95 %
H4a: AR → T → TP	.71	.14	.45	1.00
H4b: AR → T → CP	.78	.14	.51	1.05
H4c: AR → T → OP	.66	.14	.40	.94

industry, thereby theoretically extending the literature on performance management, a critical but understudied research area in this industry (Altin et al., 2018). As an essential tool in human resource management (Boswell and Boudreau, 2000; Prowse and Prowse, 2009; Thomas and Bretz, 1994), performance appraisal is closely associated with talent management (e.g., decisions on promotions and dismissals), performance management (e.g., improving employee professional competence and future performance), and compensation management (e.g., performance-related financial rewards) (Thomas and Bretz, 1994; Touma, 2022; Youngcourt et al., 2007). Both managers and subordinates recognize that negative appraisal results can adversely affect the employees, leading to managers' reluctance to make negative reviews for the sake of team morale and supervisory relationships, and employees' lack of candor for their own benefits (Longenecker and Fink, 2017; Thomas and Bretz, 1994; Varma et al., 1996). Previous literature has extensively investigated potential bias from the appraisers' perspective, including centrality bias (little variance in appraisals), halo/horn effect (appraisal based on positive/negative characteristics), recency effects (appraisal merely includes recent events), leniency/strictness bias (appraisal above/below actual performance), etc. (Balzer and Sulsky, 1992; Grund and Przemeck, 2012; Prowse and Prowse, 2009). Employee performance appraisal participation is identified as a means to rectify performance appraisal bias, in turn leading to more fair and ethical appraisal results (Cawley et al., 1998; Roberts, 2003). Therefore, employee participation is considered as a value expression that provides them an opportunity to have a voice in the performance appraisal process. In other words, employees' statements during the appraisal meeting may significantly influence the performance appraisal outcome (Mulvaney, 2019). Existing literature has mainly examined the contribution of employee participation to objective and accurate performance appraisal results (Kathiravan et al., 2017; Roberts, 1994). Scant research has been conducted on the different approaches proactively adopted by employees in the participation process and the pertinence of these approaches in further shifting performance appraisal outcomes. As such, the current research takes a step forward by demonstrating that the adoption of stealing thunder, as a proactive tactic during the performance appraisal, did benefit the employees in their performance appraisal results.

Additionally, the current research contributes to the literature on impression management. Scholars have indicated that employees adopt impression management during the performance appraisal interview to achieve favorable results (Wayne and Kacmar, 1991). For example, managers dealing with negative financial reports have been found to utilize impression management to obtain a better performance evaluation by stakeholders (Merkel-Davies and Brennan, 2011). In line with enhancing performance appraisal by stakeholders, corporate actors are inclined to embed impression management in their external discourse confronting legitimacy-related crises (Allen and Caillouet, 1994). The existing literature on impression management has presented the application of denial (Von Hippel et al., 2005), deception (Weiss and Feldman, 2006), and ingratiation (Allen and Caillouet, 1994) as specific strategies to ameliorate the self-image. Distinctive from the approaches that apply impression management via concealment of vulnerability, stealing thunder is marked by openness, honesty, and confession (Arpan and Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005). Researchers have identified stealing thunder as a novel service recovery strategy to improve customer loyalty (Guchait et al., 2019), a tactic to reduce the negative impact on an evaluative audience in a courtroom (Dolnik et al., 2003), and a crisis

communication strategy to promote communication flow between organizations and journalists (Arpan and Pompper, 2003). Confirming the effectiveness of stealing thunder, the current findings demonstrated its effectiveness as a novel tactic in impression management by showing its positive effect on the performance appraisal ratings following personal transgressions, thereby extending the literature on impression management.

Also, the current set of studies expands the research scope of impression management and performance appraisal by proposing trust as a mediator to explain how stealing thunder influences performance appraisal outcomes, in relation to the inoculation theory. Extensive research has investigated the positive effects of trust in employers on employees' task performance (Kim et al., 2018), job satisfaction (Gill, 2008), and organizational commitment (Xiong et al., 2016). There is a dearth of investigation regarding supervisors' trust toward subordinates and its effects on subsequent performance appraisals. The present research illuminates the leaders' trust in subordinates derived from employees' stealing thunder and its positive impacts on sequential performance appraisals. Based on a biological analogy, the inoculation theory explains the emergence of individual attitudinal resistance against potential attacks by forewarning others through weakened negative information (McGuire, 1961). Most previous literature adopted the inoculation theory in the political, health, marketing, and public relation disciplines to reveal people's resistance to persuasion against inoculation messaging (Ivanov et al., 2020). In line with this previous research, the current set of studies applied the inoculation theory in the context of performance appraisals and found that the preemptive self-disclosure of negative information, namely, stealing thunder, could ameliorate performance appraisals via the mediating role of trust in employees.

Last, drawing upon the attribution theory, the current research investigated the role of attribution of responsibility as a contingent factor in the effects of the stealing thunder strategy on performance appraisals. As revealed by the attribution theory, individuals intend to arrive at causal inferences about their successes and failures (Martinko et al., 2007), which leads to significant changes in individuals' subsequent emotions, behaviors, and treatment (Martinko et al., 2006). In the hospitality context, existing literature has mainly investigated the effects of attribution practices adopted by organizations during the service recovery process, suggesting that self-attribution is positively related to customers repurchase intentions (Fu et al., 2021; Ukeje et al., 2021), customer satisfaction (Jiang et al., 2010), and customer brand loyalty (Orth et al., 2012). Likewise, numerous studies have revealed the importance of attributions in performance appraisal process (i.e., Levy and Williams, 2004; Boachie-Mensah and Seidu, 2012). Unfortunately, the majority of research focused on how supervisors' attribution for employees' performance alters the consequence of performance evaluation (Su et al., 2017; Martinko et al., 2006). Limited studies explored the influence of employees' attribution style on their performance appraisal, revealing that diffusion of responsibility and apologies toward a negative event reduces the possibility of being punished (i.e., Gundlach et al., 2003). In line with this view, this research integrates the attribution of responsibility derived from the stealing thunder strategy with impression management to investigate the influences of different attributional styles on performance appraisals, finding that accepting responsibility for transgressions (vs. attributing failures to others) leads to better performance appraisals from the tactics of stealing thunder. Doing so not only extends the nomological framework of attribution theory by applying it in the research of stealing thunder, but also shifts the focus from evaluators' attribution to actors' attribution during the performance appraisal process and comprehend the scholarly understanding of different outcomes of employees' attribution approaches.

6.2. Practical implications

Practically, this study provides several implications for hospitality

managers, supervisors at difference levels, and employees. First, stealing thunder is a promising impression management technique for employees. Employees can effectively reduce the negative impact of negative information on performance appraisal outcomes by revealing negative information about themselves prior to it being disclosed by a third party. This research indicated that employees who employed stealing thunder strategies (self-disclosure of their workplace mistakes) during the performance appraisal process received significant better performance evaluations than when they did not apply the stealing thunder strategy. Not only does using the stealing thunder strategy reduce negative impressions of the individual adopting the self-disclosure, but it also creates greater trust between the appraiser (i.e., manager, supervisor) and the individual. Furthermore, when a stealing thunder strategy is coupled with the acceptance of responsibility, the employee received significantly higher performance ratings utilizing the combined strategies. This finding has the potential to encourage employees to speak up about their wrongdoings without fear of retribution or punishment.

Second, from managers' perspective, performance appraisal is one indispensable function of human resource management that determines the promotions, pay raise, merit pay, termination and demotion, as well as employee development and feedback (Grote, 2017). Given its importance, performance appraisal should be efficient and effective. On the one hand, the performance appraisal should be conducted in a time-efficient way in that information can be collected and interacted as much as possible (Buckingham and Goodall, 2015). On the other hand, to reduce the rating errors and other potential bias, the information exchanged during the performance appraisal should be as accurate and honest as possible (Goler et al., 2016). In this regard, the adoption of stealing thunder is beneficial for managers to collect authentic information in a time-saving way, which improves the overall efficiency and effectiveness of performance appraisal as an essential HR function.

Third, from the organization's perspective, a high-performance and ethical organizations should encourage such qualities as authenticity and honesty among employees, by creating a psychological safe work environment wherein employees do not feel obliged to hide information or lie (Jordan et al., 2022). The adoption of stealing thunder characterized by self-disclosure is likely to contribute to the creation of a work environment that facilitates ethical practice as authentic behaviors are not punished, but accepted and understood.

6.3. Limitations and future research

The current research contains some limitations that could be addressed in future research. Both studies were conducted in the U.S. cultural context wherein errors are generally more accepted, and risk-taking is more encouraged (Yao et al., 2019). Therefore, it is likely that stealing thunder may be popular and effective in the U.S. context. Future research should consider replicating the current findings in different countries where uncertainty avoidance tendency is high (e.g., some Eastern countries). Scholars can also investigate whether cultural differences influence the effectiveness of stealing thunder on performance evaluations. While the current study investigated attribution tendency of the employees (taking responsibility vs blaming others for the mistake) as a boundary condition influencing the impact of stealing thunder on performance evaluations; future researchers need to consider other moderating factors such as leadership styles (transformational vs transactional) and severity of the mistakes (high vs low).

Additionally, the current research identifies trust as an underlying mechanism that explains how stealing thunder and accepting responsibility improve performance ratings. This is an investigation of the cognitive mediating process. Future research should consider managers' emotional experiences that are triggered by employees' stealing thunder (e.g., contentment, admiration) that further contribute to favorable ratings. By doing this, we would gain more insights on how stealing thunder benefits the employees in the performance appraisal context.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. - Study 1 Scenarios

Stealing Thunder

Instructions.

Please read the directions very carefully. Picture yourself as the person in the scenario in the following section. Answer the following questions based on the scenario that was provided.

General Information.

You are a manager at Restaurant XXX. As a manager you are responsible to conduct performance evaluations of every restaurant employee. In order to evaluate performance of employees, performance appraisal meetings are scheduled once a year at Restaurant XXX.

Specific Information.

You just finished a performance appraisal meeting with one of the line cooks in the Restaurant, Mr. David Smith. At the meeting you provided positive feedback for things that David did well and gave him constructive feedback in the areas which needed improvement. Then together you agreed on the target goals for next year. It was a standard performance appraisal meeting.

However, during the appraisal meeting, David admitted himself that he made a mistake. The mistake is that last week he came to work sick.

Restaurant XXX is serious about food safety. The company has a sick policy. Restaurant XXX encourage employees to stay home while they are sick. The company offers paid-time-off. If an employee feels sick, whether at work or at home, they need to inform their manager right away.

NO Stealing Thunder

Instructions.

Please read the directions very carefully. Picture yourself as the person in the scenario in the following section. Answer the following questions based on the scenario that was provided.

General Information.

You are a manager at Restaurant XXX. As a manager you are responsible to conduct performance evaluations of every restaurant employee. In order to evaluate performance of employees, performance appraisal meetings are scheduled once a year at Restaurant XXX.

Specific Information.

You just finished a performance appraisal meeting with one of the line cooks in the Restaurant, Mr. David Smith. At the meeting you provided positive feedback for things that David did well and gave him constructive feedback in the areas which needed improvement. Then together you agreed on the target goals for next year. It was a standard performance appraisal meeting.

However, after the appraisal meeting, you found out that David had come to work sick last week. You were informed by one of David's co-workers. And the information was confirmed by one of your shift managers. But David did not admit or mention anything about this mistake during the appraisal meeting.

Restaurant XXX is serious about food safety. The company has a sick policy. Restaurant XXX encourage employees to stay home while they are sick. The company offers paid-time-off. If an employee feels sick, whether at work or at home, they need to inform their manager right away.

Appendix B. - Study 3 scenarios

Take Responsibility

Instructions.

Please read the directions very carefully. Picture yourself as the person in the scenario in the following section. Answer the following questions based on the scenario that was provided.

General Information.

You are a manager at Restaurant XXX. As a manager you are responsible to conduct performance evaluations of every restaurant employee. In order to evaluate performance of employees, performance appraisal meetings are scheduled once a year at Restaurant XXX.

Specific Information.

You just finished a performance appraisal meeting with one of the line cooks in the Restaurant, Mr. David Smith. At the meeting you provided positive feedback for things that David did well and gave him constructive feedback in the areas which needed improvement. Then together you agreed on the target goals for next year. It was a standard performance appraisal meeting.

However, during the appraisal meeting, David admitted himself that he made a mistake. The mistake is that last week he came to work sick. David acknowledged that he was guilty of knowingly coming to work sick which was a violation. He stated that he had no one to blame but himself and accepted complete responsibility.

Restaurant XXX is serious about food safety. The company has a sick policy. Restaurant XXX encourage employees to stay home while they are sick. The company offers paid-time-off. If an employee feels sick, whether at work or at home, they need to inform their manager right away.

Blame Others

Instructions.

Please read the directions very carefully. Picture yourself as the person in the scenario in the following section. Answer the following questions based on the scenario that was provided.

General Information.

You are a manager at Restaurant XXX. As a manager you are responsible to conduct performance evaluations of every restaurant employee. In order to evaluate performance of employees, performance appraisal meetings are scheduled once a year at Restaurant XXX.

Specific Information.

You just finished a performance appraisal meeting with one of the line cooks in the Restaurant, Mr. David Smith. At the meeting you provided positive feedback for things that David did well and gave him constructive feedback in the areas which needed improvement. Then together you agreed on the target goals for next year. It was a standard performance appraisal meeting.

However, during the appraisal meeting, David admitted himself that he made a mistake. The mistake is that last week he came to work sick. David acknowledged that he knowingly came to work sick which was a violation. However, David stated that he was only partially guilty and did not accept the responsibility for the mistake. He placed the blame on other individuals for making him commit the mistake.

Restaurant XXX is serious about food safety. The company has a sick policy. Restaurant XXX encourage employees to stay home while they are sick. The company offers paid-time-off. If an employee feels sick, whether at work or at home, they need to inform their manager right away.

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